

value. Otherwise you should ignore this setting, leaving it at the minimum value of 100.

Fast Initialisation: Checking this setting will enable fast initialisation, which will reduce the startup time for XP. If you encounter problems with your mouse when this is checked, try leaving it unchecked.

For your network controller, you have two “optimise for” options: throughput and CPU. This setting really makes no difference, and optimising for throughput could have an effect only if you’re on a LAN. Some people, though, encounter problems if the network controller is optimised for throughput.

As a final example, consider the COM ports, which allow communication devices such as modems, printers and mice to interact with the motherboard. You can set the bits per second, data bits, parity, stop bits, flow control, whether to use FIFO buffers, and how large the receive and transmit buffers should be. The defaults are usually sufficient, but you might need to change them in certain instances. For example, you might just find that the “bits per second” for your 56K modem is set to lower than 115000: set it to this value for the best speed. Also, you might find that “flow control” is set to ‘None’; set it to ‘Hardware’ for best results from your modem.

The above is intended to make you aware of the level of control possible through the Device Manager. It’s not a tweaking tool—if everything’s going fine, don’t mess with it! However, the Device Manager is the first place you should be looking if a device has problems.